weapons could encourage destabilizing behavior even if states calculate rationally and behave strategically. I offer such an approach, arguing that even if they devise policy in a largely rational manner, newly nuclear states may decide not to behave cautiously. Instead, under certain circumstances, nuclear weapons can create strong incentives for rational states to adopt aggressive, extremely risky policies. Thus the spread of nuclear weapons can destabilize the international security environment even apart from the organizational logic that has so far driven the arguments of proliferation pessimists. In some cases, rational proliferators can be dangerous proliferators.

How could the acquisition of nuclear weapons create incentives for a state to behave in a destabilizing manner? Suppose that a state was dissatisfied with the location of its borders and militarily weak relative to its primary adversary. In this situation, the state's leaders would like to alter its territorial boundaries but would fear that doing so could trigger retaliation by the stronger adversary. Such retaliation could result in catastrophic defeat, involving a significant loss of territory or even of sovereignty. Thus the leaders of the weak, dissatisfied state would probably have to live with territorial boundaries that they viewed as undesirable.

Nuclear weapons would change this situation in two important ways. First, nuclear weapons would afford the weaker state a shield against its adversary's superior conventional military capabilities. If the strong state ever threatened the weak state with catastrophic military defeat, the weak state could respond with a nuclear attack. The strong state could still retaliate in the event of provocation by its weaker opponent. But the danger of a nuclear response would constrain the strong state, making it much less likely to launch a full-scale conventional attack against its adversary. This would not change the actual balance of power between the two sides. Nuclear danger, however, would limit the strong state's willingness to use its military capabilities. And thus nuclear weapons would nullify a good deal of the strong state's conventional military advantage. These developments could embolden the weak state to behave in ways that were previously too dangerous. Before acquiring nuclear weapons, the weak state had to fear that attempts to alter territorial boundaries